



ASRock Z170 Extreme7+

Giving you more flexibility with your Skylake configuration

ASRock too sent us their top Z170 board and it hops ahead of the competition by not only providing the same set of features as the competition but by giving you more of each feature to afford the user greater flexibility with their Skylake configuration.

For starters, you have three M.2 slots, each of which is an x4 PCIe slot so RAID speeds easily hit 3400 MB/s. You not only get three M.2 ports but also three SATA Express ports. Now, all the other Z170 boards have USB 3.1 Type C connectors on the rear but



Price
₹21,499
(Approx.)

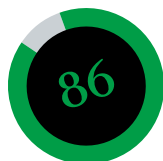
ASRock has provided a 3.5-inch drive bay adapter to bring the two USB 3.1 ports to the front which is something that cabinet manufacturers are yet to provide.

While we did see Giga-byte's board with two GbE ports, they didn't support Teaming but the Killer E2400 port had configurable QoS settings. The ASRock Z170 Extreme7+ not only has Teaming because both ports are Intel GbE but you get a free license for cFosSpeed which has QoS settings of its own as well. Moreover, one of the GbE ports happens to be the latest from Intel that supports Intel V-Pro.

When it comes to audio, ASRock went with Realtek's ALC1150 channelled through an aftermarket op-amp and isolated circuitry which they call Purity Sound 3.

ASRock has really pushed the envelope with the Z170 Extreme7+ and the board is part of its launch lineup, which makes us wonder what else ASRock has in store with its future SKUs.

Mithun Mobandas



Features93
Build79

Specifications

Chipset: Intel Z170; **Memory support:** 4x3600(OC)MHz upto 64GB; **LAN:** Intel I211-AT + I219-V Gigabit Ethernet; **Audio:** ALC1150 7.1; **SATA:** 10x SATA III; **Expansion:** 4x PCIe X16(x16+x8+x8+x4); **Dimensions (LxWxD):** 305 mm x 244 mm; **Warranty:** 3 years.

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TP-Link Archer D9 Router

Value for money in the enthusiast segment

With AC1900 routers being the sweet spot currently in terms of performance and affordability there are quite a few options to choose from and TP-Link's Archer D9 is the latest entrant in that pool with a significant price difference, especially for an ADSL router which tend to cost a little more than non-ADSL models. The question arises as to what gives it this economical advantage.

For starters, the router weighs a lot less than its counterparts but runs on the same BCM4709 as they all do. Secondly, a lot of the expensive routers tend to have a much more polished user interface while the Archer D9 sticks



Price
₹13,999

to what you find in its budget segment routers.

Not that there's anything wrong with it, it's just that such UI are more preferred by enthusiasts and can be a bit cumbersome for first timers. The Archer D9 is designed without any wall mount holes in the rear but you can always flip it upside down and use the stand as a wall mount with a slight reorientation of the antennae to compensate for the awkward positioning.

The router's performance isn't affected by the price cut with what we observed, though the effects of sustained high throughput performance over long periods of time is something that we didn't have the time to figure out. And transfer rates for the USB 3.0 port on the rear was a little lesser than what we've seen in competing routers. However, given its pricing there isn't any other router than can provide the same level of performance and the UI is something you only fiddle with once in a blue moon. These factors explain the Archer D9's pricing.

Mithun Mobandas



Performance.....79
Features68
Build Quality75

Specifications

Wireless LAN Chip: Broadcom BCM4709; **Memory:** 128 MB; **Protocols:** 802.11ac; **Bandwidth:** 1900(1300@5GHz+600@2.4GHz) Mbps; **Ethernet:** 4x LAN GbE, 1x RJ-11 Ports; **USB:** 1x USB 2.0, 1x USB 3.0; **Warranty:** 3 years

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